

Diet Approaches Based on Food Choices



Mediterranean Diet

A diet common among populations living near the Mediterranean (Italy, Greece, and Spain) that includes liberal use of fresh vegetables, fruit, grains, nuts, and olive oil. Fish, poultry, and dairy are included in moderate amounts, while red meat consumption is low.

ADVANTAGES

- Reduced risk for many chronic diseases
- Decreased mortality (death) rate
- Potential weight loss

DISADVANTAGES

- May require additional food prep time
- Red wine should be consumed in moderation
- Potentially difficult adherence



Vegan/Vegetarian Diet

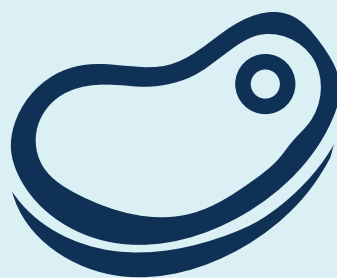
A vegan diet is a plant-based diet that excludes all animal products. Vegetarian diets abstain from meat and poultry but may allow some animal products like eggs and dairy.

ADVANTAGES

- Reduced risk of heart disease and cancer
- Improved blood glucose levels in diabetics
- Potential weight loss

DISADVANTAGES

- Potential for inadequate protein intake
- Risk for suboptimal vitamin B₁₂, calcium and iron intake
- Risk for suboptimal omega-3 fatty acids and creatine intake
- Potentially difficult adherence



Paleo Diet

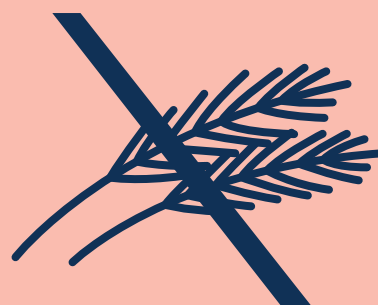
A dietary approach that mimics that of our ancestors. It calls for the avoidance of grains, legumes, dairy products, and most conventionally processed foods.

ADVANTAGES

- Weight loss
- Improved blood markers (e.g., cholesterol, triglycerides, insulin)
- Decreased consumption of hyperpalatable (sugary, salty, fatty) foods

DISADVANTAGES

- Unnecessarily restricts healthful foods (e.g., whole grains, legumes, dairy)
- Does not appear superior to other diets for weight loss
- Potentially difficult adherence



Gluten-Free Diet

Gluten is the term used to describe a collection of proteins found in grains such as wheat, barley, and rye. A gluten-free diet is typically prescribed for patients with celiac disease or a wheat allergy.

ADVANTAGES

- Removes GI distress for individuals with celiac disease
- May improve GI distress for individuals with a gluten intolerance
- May be beneficial for those with hashimoto's thyroiditis

DISADVANTAGES

- Inferior to many other diets for weight loss
- Inferior to many other diets for improved health markers
- Potentially difficult adherence



DASH Diet

The dietary approaches to stop hypertension (DASH) diet was developed to help people lower blood pressure without medication. It involves consuming fruits, vegetables, whole grains, low-fat dairy, fish, poultry, legumes, and vegetable oils, while minimizing saturated fat and sugary beverages and sweets.

ADVANTAGES

- Reduced blood pressure
- Improved overall cardiovascular health
- Potentially can reduce body weight and body fat

DISADVANTAGES

- May require additional food-prep time
- The primary emphasis is lowering blood pressure not body weight
- Potentially difficult adherence